

ESSENTIAL

Visitor Visa Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - NZeTA vs. full application, the genuine visitor test, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the Visitor Visa is - and who actually needs it

The Visitor Visa lets you travel to New Zealand for tourism, visiting family or friends, or other short-term temporary purposes, generally for up to 9 months within an 18-month period, decided by Immigration New Zealand (INZ), part of the Ministry of Business, Innovation and Employment. Most nationalities never apply for it directly - they use the NZeTA instead. A full Visitor Visa is for non-waiver nationalities, or for circumstances the NZeTA doesn't cover, such as longer stays or specific supported categories.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. Confirm you actually need a Visitor Visa	Check whether your nationality is visa-waiver (NZeTA route) or requires a full application.
2. Create an Immigration New Zealand online account	Applications are submitted through INZ's own online system.
3. Gather supporting documents	Financial evidence, travel/health/character documents as required, and a sponsorship form if relying on a sponsor.
4. Pay the fee (includes the IVL)	The Visitor Visa fee for this route includes the International Visitor Conservation and Tourism Levy.
5. Submit and respond to any further information requests	INZ may ask for additional evidence before deciding.
6. Decision	Generally decided on the written file - interviews are uncommon for standard visitor applications.
7. Get your visa	An eVisa (electronically linked to your passport), not a physical sticker.

The genuine visitor test, explained properly

INZ's core question isn't primarily "do you have enough money" - it's whether you're a genuine temporary visitor who intends to leave before your visa expires. Financial evidence, ties to home, and a specific, credible itinerary all feed into this single assessment, rather than being separate pass/fail thresholds.

Longer stays: the Parent Boost Visitor Visa

Parents and grandparents of New Zealand citizens or residents have access to a distinct long-stay visitor category (commonly known as Parent Boost), allowing multiple entries and materially longer cumulative stays than the standard Visitor Visa, subject to its own separate eligibility and financial/sponsorship requirements. If this applies to you, confirm the current specific criteria directly with INZ rather than assuming the standard Visitor Visa rules apply.

Frequently asked questions

Can I work on a Visitor Visa?

No - general employment isn't permitted, though some specific visitor categories allow limited activities such as certain unpaid or short-term arrangements under separate instructions.

What if I'm also visiting Australia or another country on the same trip?

New Zealand isn't part of the Schengen area or a similar shared-visa bloc - your New Zealand Visitor Visa is assessed and issued independently of any other country's visa.

What if I'm refused?

See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for what's actually available given the limited formal appeal rights for standard visitor refusals.